

Baroque in Italy

Following the Council of Trent, the Roman Catholic Church decreed that art should portray biblical truths, depicting subjects clearly, powerfully and with dignity, without the stylistic airs of Mannerism. The resulting art was extravagant, emotional and often featured dramatic contrasts of highlight and shadow.

Annibale Carracci (1560–1609), one of the first painters in a movement later named the Baroque, produced energetic, colourful works inspired by Titian and Veronese, with expressive brushstrokes and atmospheric light. Pietro da Cortona (1596–1669) produced large, busy scenes, while Guido Reni (1575–1642) and Domenichino (1581–1641), influenced by Raphael, both pursued a more classical approach, with richly coloured, idealized images. In an era that was difficult for female artists, Artemisia Gentileschi (1593–c.1656) painted pictures of powerful women from mythology and the Bible, creating strong tonal contrasts influenced by Caravaggio. Baroque sculptors included Gian Lorenzo Bernini and Alessandro Algardi (1598–1654).



Gentileschi, *Judith and her maidservant*, 1612–3